

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

CORE FORMULA

Ask from genuine interest -> Open-ended -> Follow up on what they said

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask one question in your next conversation that you are genuinely curious about — not to make a point, not to steer, just to understand.

BEST FOR

- Building genuine relationships
- Understanding someone's position before responding
- Drawing out quiet people in group settings
- Getting better information before making decisions

PHRASE BANK

Curiosity Openers · Questions from genuine interest

- "What made you want to do it that way?"
- "How did you arrive at that?"
- "What is the part that worries you most about this?"
- "What would need to be true for you to change your view on that?"
- "What am I missing from my read of this?"
- "What has your experience of this actually been like?"
- "What is the thing you are not saying?"
- "If you had to name the real issue, what would it be?"

Follow-Up Questions · Going deeper on what they said

- "Say more about that."
- "What do you mean when you say X?"
- "Can you give me an example?"
- "What happened next?"
- "What was that like for you?"
- "How long has that been the case?"

Quick Curiosity · Small questions that open doors

- "What happened there?"
- "How come?"
- "What is behind that?"
- "And then what?"
- "What is the story there?"
- "Compared to what?"

Professional Curiosity · Better information before decisions

- "What would change your estimate?"
- "What did you consider and reject before landing on this?"
- "Where is this most likely to break?"
- "What does the data not show us?"
- "Who disagrees with this, and what is their strongest point?"
- "If this fails in six months, what will the reason have been?"

Curiosity Under Fire · Asking instead of defending

- "Before I respond — what is the strongest version of your concern?"
- "What would I need to show you for this to feel safe?"
- "Help me see what you are seeing, because we are reading this differently."
- "What is at stake for you in this that I might be missing?"
- "You clearly feel strongly about this. What is underneath that?"
- "What is the question you think I am avoiding?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Rhetorical question that is really a statement: 'Don't you think X?'
Better: What do you think about X?
Best: Open, genuinely curious question with no preferred answer baked in.
2. Weak: Rapid-fire questions that feel like an interrogation
Better: I have a few questions — let me start with the most important one.
Best: One question. Let them answer fully. Follow up on what they actually said.
3. Weak: Asking a question and then answering it yourself
Better: What is your view? I have mine but I want yours first.
Best: Ask and then stay quiet. Let them actually answer.

DECISION TREE

If You want to ask a question but have an agenda

Check: are you asking to understand, or to lead them somewhere? Adjust accordingly.
"I want to understand this before I have a view on it."

If Someone gives a short answer you want to expand

Use a simple open follow-up.
"Tell me more about that."

If You are in a group and someone is not speaking

Direct a specific curiosity question to them.
"I was curious to hear your read on this — you have been thinking about it longer than most of us."

If You ask a question and they deflect

Do not chase it. Ask something adjacent that is easier to answer.
"What is the part you can answer?"

SCENARIOS

Someone proposes an idea you want to understand before judging

Ask how they arrived at it before you respond. — "How did you land on that approach?"

Interview or assessment: listening for what is not being said

Ask for the real version beneath the polished one. — "If you could be honest about what was hard in that, what would you say?"

Networking: making a connection feel real

Ask one question you are genuinely interested in the answer to. — "What is the part of your work that most people misunderstand?"

Conflict: trying to understand their position before responding

Ask before you explain your view. — "Help me understand where you are coming from before I respond."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the other person has clearly signalled they do not want to discuss the topic further.
- In time-pressured situations where questions derail rather than deepen.
- When used to gather information while performing interest — the inauthenticity will eventually surface.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — One real question

Ask one question today that you are genuinely curious about. Note what you learn.

Day 2 — Follow up on the answer

Ask a follow-up question based on what they actually said — not a prepared question.

Day 3 — No agenda test

Ask a question with no preferred answer. Let their response surprise you.

Day 4 — Quiet voices

In a group setting, direct one curiosity question to someone who has been quiet.

Day 5 — Depth question

Ask a question that goes one level deeper than the surface topic.

Day 6 — Stay quiet after asking

Ask a question and then stay completely quiet until they are fully done answering.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did you learn something surprising this week? Did any conversations open up in a way they would not have otherwise?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask from genuine curiosity rather than to make a point?
- Was my question open-ended — not a rhetorical statement?
- Did I follow up on what they actually said?
- Did I stay quiet after asking and let them answer fully?
- Did I ask one question at a time?
- Did I avoid answering my own question?
- Did I learn something I did not already know?